Engaging in Peace, Dialogue, and Coexistence

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Abstract

This paper offers an introductory reflection on the workshop track of the Participatory Design Conference (PDC) 2026, outlining the key questions and perspectives that emerge from it. Participatory Design (PD) is a growing international academic and practice-based field, with an extensive body of work addressing a wide range of questions surrounding the idea of designing together [14]. Across these developments, one practice consistently sits at the core of PD: the workshop. Workshops constitute intentional moments of engagement with others within research and professional projects. This paper introduces the workshop track of the Participatory Design Conference (PDC) 2026, framed by the theme Peace, Dialogue, Coexistence. Building on the historical role of workshops within PD, we approach creating a workshop track for the conference as temporary democratic infrastructures where participation is staged, negotiated, and critically examined. Twelve workshops were selected within four thematic clusters: (a) Living Together Beyond the Human; (b) Place, Spatiality, and Situated Participation foregrounds; (c) Conflict, Dialogue, and Peacebuilding; and (d) Narratives, Emotions, and the Politics of Participation. Across these trajectories, workshops are understood as designed situations that distribute agency, structure tension, and materialise future conditions for coexistence. Significally, the workshop track at PDC 2026 reveals a constellation of experimental practices concerned with how participation can infrastructurally support plural forms of living together.

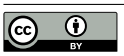
CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → Participatory design.

Keywords

Workshop, Embodied experience, Situated participation

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1 Introduction

Participatory Design (PD) is a growing international academic and practice-based field, with an extensive body of work addressing a wide range of questions surrounding the idea of designing together, see for instance [14]. Scholarship in PD has explored diverse aspects of participatory practice, including forms of engagement [10], theories of participation and invitation [9], temporality [11], power relations [3], and cultural and environmental concerns [12, 15], among others. Across these developments, one practice consistently sits at the core of participatory design: the workshop. Workshops constitute intentional moments of engagement with others within research and professional projects, activating design processes to be shaped by multiple actors connected, directly or indirectly, to the issues at stake. Through workshops, PD practitioners gather people to collectively explore, negotiate, and act upon shared issues.

Rooted in the 70s through various social movements across the globe, such as the workplace democracy movement, the community design centers and collaborative design initiatives [10, 13], the idea of bringing people together through workshops has evolved alongside the field itself. Today, workshops address increasingly complex and interconnected issues, ranging from product and service design to social innovation, policy-making, decolonial practices, and more-than-human relations. Reflecting this expansion, workshops in PD now take a wide variety of forms, bringing together heterogeneous participants and deploying diverse modes of engagement, materials, and temporalities. Within the broader trajectory of PD, workshops have historically functioned as sites where democratic commitments are enacted rather than merely discussed: PD has positioned itself as a practice concerned with shaping the conditions under which people can participate in decisions that affect their lives [10, 15]. Within this academic and practice-based landscape, the Participatory Design Conference (PDC) has, since its beginnings in the 1990s, functioned as a central point of connection for researchers, practitioners, students, and other actors engaged in participatory design.

2 Workshops as experiencing participation at PDC 2026

The PDC 2026 workshop program builds upon the evolution of the field, the centrality of workshops to PD and the significance of the conference to the global PD community. However, it does so under conditions of renewed urgency. Framed by the conference theme Peace, Dialogue, Coexistence, the workshop track for PDC 2026 asks how participation can sustain pluralism under conditions of conflict, ecological and political crisis, polarization, systemic inequality, and increasing uncertainty. In this perspective, the workshop track is shaped through the interplay between curatorial priorities, aimed at engaging critically with the current state of participatory design, and the arguments articulated across the submitted proposals. The resulting interpretation, organised through four clusters, reflects both a proposal to approach workshops as practices that configure the conditions of participation, and a way of making visible how participation is currently being shaped within the field.

Guiding the workshop track was a set of curatorial priorities, which include fostering active and embodied participation; foregrounding the role of artefacts and material practices in structuring interaction; engaging with politics, voice, and power; addressing tensions as constitutive of productive dialogue; making structural conditions perceptible; and engaging with pluralities across diverse ways of being and knowing fostering active and embodied participation; foregrounding the role of artefacts and material practices in structuring interaction; engaging with politics, voice, and power; addressing tensions as constitutive of productive dialogue; making structural conditions perceptible; and, finally engaging with pluralities across diverse ways of being and knowing.

In terms of promoting engagement, the workshop track has been conceived as privileging activation and experience. Engaging in workshops in PDC 2026 works as invitations into shared inquiry with knowledge generated through being together. As such, emphasis has been placed on inviting workshop formats capable of staging and engaging with participation as spaces where participatory design is enacted and interrogated in practice.

Moreover, as an in-person practice within the conference, the workshop track has been conceived as a structured environment in which dialogue, negotiation, and collective sense-making are materially configured. Hence, rather than orbiting solely around discussion, the track has been designed to create an environment where participation takes shape through spatial arrangements, engagement with materials, diverse facilitation formats, mapping devices, role-play scenarios, and collective prototyping.

Through these situated and material engagements, the track has aimed to bring together workshops capable of generating intermediate artefacts that could extend the life of participation beyond the temporal limits of a single session, functioning as mediating infrastructures within the broader PD practice and research field. While the idea of intermediate artefacts has not been rigidly defined, workshops were envisioned as producing outcomes in the shape of guidelines, thematic maps, frameworks for navigating values misalignment, or repositories of narratives functioning as infrastructural seeds that could enable participation to persist and circulate across research and practice contexts.

Whereas these dimensions concern the more practical aspects of workshop, the track also sought bring to foreground engagement with broader conceptual and structural questions. A key priority, in connection with the conference theme, was for the workshop track to hold space for engagement with issues of politics, power relations, and voice. As such, the workshop track represents a space to engage, scrutinize and co-create in relation to political structures, issues of power and privilege, and voice and agency. In this sense, the track itself constitutes a primary political gesture that opens up reflection on how publics are organised and constituted within PD in relation to local, global, and trans-local socio-political conditions. The distribution of voices, the artefacts mediating exchange, and the structuring of disagreement shape the conditions under which peace and coexistence are explored. Building on this, another dimension the workshop track sought to hold concerns the idea of tensions as productive spaces. Following recent developments in the field regarding agonism and dialogue [5], the workshop track proposes conflict, asymmetry, and infrastructural limitations as inherent conditions of democratic existence. The aim is to create settings in which diversity becomes generative, while differences are both acknowledged and emphasized. Dialogue is thus understood as a practice requiring structure and support, and coexistence as a process rehearsed and negotiated through material and relational configurations.

In relation to matters of politics and tensions, it was considered necessary for the workshop landscape at PDC 2026 to engage critically with underlying structural conditions. The track aims to promote engagements in which the socio-material, institutional, ecological, and technological infrastructures that shape participation can be rendered perceptible. Through practices such as mapping, infrastructural reflection, speculative prototyping, and governance-oriented inquiry, participation is framed as a situated and relational practice whose emancipatory potential unfolds through the scrutiny, exploration, experimentation, and co-creation with existing power structures. This perspective positions *Peace, Coexistence, and Dialogue* as a continuous process of reallocating visibility, agency, and responsibility within controversial systems.

In engaging with engagements, materiality, politics, tensions, and structural conditions, it was considered essential for the workshop track to create a space that neither implies nor presupposes unified perspectives, shared ontological grounds, or homogeneous modes of being. In this sense, plurality constituted an overarching dimension to be nurtured within the workshop landscape of the conference. Within the broader context of the conference, this epistemological stance is crucial: coexistence depends on acknowledging that no single perspective can exhaustively represent complex socio-ecological realities.

Workshops therefore operate as collective processes of sense-making, where understanding is co-constructed and provisional. In this sense, they extend the argument that PD is not only about "designing things" but about designing socio-material assemblies that gather issues and actors into deliberative formations [5]. By welcoming diverse actors, disciplinary perspectives, and more-than-human agencies, workshops challenge anthropocentric and discipline-bound models of engagement [1, 8, 16].

Coexistence is thus framed beyond human-to-human negotiation as the management of interdependencies across ecological

and infrastructural assemblages. Designing for peace, in this sense, requires attention to distributed agency and ecological regeneration alongside social justice. As such, the PDC 2026 workshop track is envisioned as a collective space for expanding the field of participation.

Conceived in this way, the workshop track at PDC 2026 operates as temporary yet consequential democratic infrastructures. It functions as designed situations in which participation is staged, negotiated, and critically examined. This resonates with DiSalvo's [6] framing of design as democratic inquiry: an experimental practice that constructs publics around issues. It also connects with the notion of micro-publics [2] as temporary spaces in which participants rehearse ways of living together through structured encounters, artefact-mediated dialogue, and collective reflection.

The following section introduces the selected workshops, using them as an entry point to examine how contemporary participatory design engages with current challenges and possibilities. The clusters make explicit how curatorial intentions take shape through distinct configurations of participatory practice, providing a lens to interpret ongoing shifts in the field.

3 Clustering Participation: Curating Themes Across the Workshop Track

Building on this vision of workshops as spaces where participation is enacted rather than described, the call for workshop proposals invited formats capable of fostering meaningful interaction through co-design, discussion, speculative prototyping, performative tactics, and hands-on collective work. Workshops were framed as spaces for collective exploration, situated inquiry, and critical engagement with the conference theme of living together. Particular emphasis was placed on formats that support participant agency, encouraging those involved to actively shape both the workshop process and its outcomes.

The call generated 77 workshop submissions, reflecting strong engagement with the conference theme across geographical regions and institutional contexts. Proposals were received from academia, industries, government, and independent practices, demonstrating the breadth of contemporary PD engagement. From these submissions, 12 workshops were selected to take place at the conference. The final selection reflects a careful balance across disciplinary backgrounds, geographical distribution, and methodological approaches, bringing together diverse perspectives on participation, coexistence, and democratic practice. Taken together, the selected workshops reveal a set of recurring concerns and orientations that cut across contexts and formats. While each proposal maintains its specificity, thematic convergences began to emerge through the review process, suggesting shared conceptual orientations across otherwise diverse formats.

The selected workshops point to a reconfiguration of participation as a practice that engages with political conditions, relational dynamics, and processes of collective transformation. The four clusters operate as interpretative lenses that support the articulation of these shifts, offering a structured way to map emerging directions within the field. They are not neutral groupings, but the result of a curatorial process shaped by the above-mentioned priorities. The focus on artefact-centered and embodied participation foregrounds workshops where materials actively mediate interaction; the attention to political and structural conditions brings forward proposals engaging with power, conflict, and governance; while the commitment to plurality supports approaches that expand participation across heterogeneous actors and perspectives. In this sense, the clusters make visible how participatory design is currently being reconfigured across different trajectories, while maintaining overlaps and productive tensions between them. Across the selected workshops, a set of recurring concerns and orientations became visible, cutting across disciplinary differences. These convergences were not predefined but emerged through the ways in which participation is framed and enacted across the proposals.

On this basis, four clusters were developed to articulate distinct yet overlapping trajectories within the workshop track: (a) Living Together Beyond the Human, which expands participation toward more-than-human and ecological relations; (b) Place, Spatiality, and Situated Participation, which foregrounds the spatial and infrastructural conditions shaping participation; (c) Conflict, Dialogue, and Peacebuilding, which addresses participation as a practice of engaging with disagreement and power; and (d) Narratives, Emotions, and the Politics of Participation, which highlights the role of experience, storytelling, and lived perspectives in shaping participatory processes. The following section outlines these clusters in detail and provides a structured lens through which to read the workshop program as a whole.

3.1 Living Together Beyond the Human

Living Together Beyond the Human cluster encapsulates a commitment to expanding participation and relationships beyond only human stakeholders, inviting broader perspectives in PD and coexistence. This approach challenges the prevailing human-centred worldview, urging us to consider the intricate entanglements between humans, non-human entities like animals, plants, and technologies, as well as diverse environments and longer temporal scales. By moving away from anthropocentric framings, workshops under this theme engage deeply with multispecies relations, ecological conflicts, and pluriversal mapping.

The cluster focuses on coexistence between humans, non-humans, technologies, and ecosystems, often employing speculative, cartographic, or material practices to foster inclusive participation. Central concerns revolve around interdependence, long-term living together, ecological conflict, and governance that is not solely human-centric. This aligns strongly with the PDC26 call to rethink coexistence beyond human actors, recognising the necessity for frameworks and participatory practices that reflect the complexity of contemporary ecological, technological, and social realities. The workshops are committed to developing strategies for genuinely inclusive coexistence, considering the needs and impacts of both human and non-human entities.

Despite these progressive intentions, translating more-than-human and pluriversal concerns into clear, actionable participatory mechanisms remains a challenge. Many struggle to articulate how non-human relations and interests can be materially enacted within participatory processes, especially in terms of negotiating relationships among diverse stakeholders. The underdeveloped dimension of relational negotiation highlights the need for robust methods

that ensure the principle of living together in plural contexts is not just theorised but practised concretely and impactfully. Moving forward, future efforts should address this gap by designing participatory mechanisms that genuinely accommodate and enact the interests of all living stakeholders, thereby advancing the ethos of living together beyond the human.

All three proposals within this cluster share a central concern: expanding the scope of participation to include multispecies relations and ecological perspectives. By doing so, they address the necessity of rethinking coexistence and governance in ways that recognise interdependence among humans, non-humans, and ecosystems. The common thread is a commitment to developing participatory frameworks and practices that reflect the complexity and plurality of contemporary ecological, technological, and social realities.

More-than-human and long-term living together workshop by Saez Martinez et al. is distinct in its methodological approach, guiding participants through the phases of Field of Conflict, Seeding and Flourishing. It uniquely emphasizes the integration of all living stakeholders, including technologies and policy agents, with the aim of designing for lasting community benefit. The focus is on crafting actionable strategies for genuinely inclusive coexistence, considering the needs and impacts of both human and non-human entities.

Bello et al., in the *Beyond SDGs: Pluriversal Interspecies Council for Post-development Futures* workshop, invite participants to critically reconsider the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and to collaboratively formulate post-development principles. By blending perspectives from Colombia and Italy, it facilitates participants to shift between human and more-than-human roles, mapping harm and care in a holistic manner. This approach foregrounds the importance of pluriversal thinking and the co-creation of futures that transcend conventional development paradigms.

Pluriversal Mapping workshop, proposed by Salgado Cofré et al., lies in its examination of contradictions such as resource exploitation and ecosystem disruption, which exacerbate the climate crisis. Through participatory and speculative design methods, it encourages reimagining coexistence between humans and more-than-human entities, particularly in contexts affected by extractivism. This workshop highlights speculative and cartographic practices as tools for envisioning alternative, more equitable forms of living together.

This cluster reveals a fundamental tension in participatory design: while more-than-human perspectives are increasingly invoked, participation risks being operationalised through human-centered logics. What is at stake is not the extension of participation to additional actors, but a reconfiguration of what participation entails, where agency is distributed, temporalities are non-linear, and relations exceed representational frameworks. Without this shift, more-than-human participation continues remaining a conceptual claim rather than a material practice. Moving ahead, the challenge lies in translating more-than-human and pluriversal concerns into clear, actionable participatory mechanisms. While these workshops open-up vital questions about coexistence, interdependence, and non-anthropocentric governance, there remains a pressing need to articulate how non-human relations and interests can be materially enacted in participatory processes. Future efforts should focus on developing robust methods for negotiating relationships among diverse stakeholders, human and non-human alike, and ensuring that the principle of living together in plural contexts is not only theorised but practised in concrete, impactful ways.

3.2 Place, Spatiality, and Situated Participation

A second cluster, Place, Spatiality, and Situated participation, emerging across the PDC 2026 workshop submissions foregrounds place, territory, and spatiality as constitutive dimensions of PD itself: these workshops insist on the fundamentally situated character of participation. Indeed, it unfolds within specific socio-material arrangements, infrastructural conditions, and layered histories of place; it is shaped by conflicts over land, by ecological fragilities, by institutional sedimentations, and by everyday spatial practices. This cluster grounds itself in the understanding that spatiality is not a neutral backdrop for relational processes, but a contested political terrain shaped by power and exclusion. These workshops resist to abstract lived territories into generic contexts. Instead, they position place as an epistemic and political condition for participation. In this sense, spatiality is not simply the "where" of participation but part of its ontological grounding: it structures who speaks, what can be imagined, which actors, human and more-than-human ones, are recognized, and how power circulates. Across the cluster, design charrettes, mapping, role-play simulations, spatial storytelling, and infrastructural analysis are mobilized as ways to render visible these entanglements and to experiment with alternative territorial futures.

The workshop *Digital Participatory Toolkit for Conflict-Sensitive Planning in Mining Regions* by Pantić and colleagues offers an example of participation as spatial negotiation. Grounded in mining regions marked by socio-environmental tension, the workshop frames spatial planning as both an arena of contestation and a platform for dialogue. Here, territory evolves from a passive container to a conflictual socio-material assemblage where economic imperatives, environmental degradation, and community well-being collide. Through a structured sequence combining analog GeoDesign, role-play, and a Digital Participatory Toolkit (DPT), participants inhabit stakeholder positions such as citizens, NGOs, mining companies, local authorities and collectively design spatial interventions. The process makes visible how proposals materialize in space and how tools reframe trade-offs and expose unanticipated consequences. Importantly, planners (played by facilitators) curate the evaluative categories, thereby surfacing questions of power and infrastructural mediation. Participation becomes an exercise in navigating spatial "hotspots," where misalignments crystallize and negotiation is required.

While Pantić et al. focus on extractive territories, *The Living Territory: Participatory Design as an Ecology of Regeneration* by Braga de Araújo and João Ribeiro Gomes expands the spatial lens toward regeneration and more-than-human coexistence. Framing territory as a living organism, the workshop proposes PD as a "collective immune system" capable of detecting imbalances and restoring relationships. Using a simulated coastal setting as a case study, participants collaboratively map social and ecological dynamics, construct territory-personas (including more-than-human actors), and prototype regenerative interventions. The workshop unfolds in phases, Seed, Germination, Fruiting, culminating in a

collectively produced "Map of Living Principles". Spatiality here is relational and processual: places are understood as evolving ecosystems shaped by tourism pressures, climate transitions, and cultural practices. Designers are repositioned from solution providers to mediators of pluriverse ecologies, echoing debates within the *Living Together Beyond the Human* cluster. Indeed, this workshop explicitly mobilizes regenerative design and pluriverse thinking, situating PD within broader political-ecological transformations. Participation is thus enacted as an embodied, spatially grounded co-production of territorial futures.

A more explicitly theoretical engagement with spatiality is developed in Exploring the Entanglement of Participatory Design, Spatiality and Place by Binder et al.. Responding to what they identify as a relative neglect of spatial dimensions in PD's "fourth wave" characterized by an increasingly intimate entanglement of human and digital technology, the workshop draws on assemblage theory and entanglement perspectives to interrogate how space and place both shape and are shaped by participatory processes. Using a design charrette format, participants bring case studies and collaboratively map the entanglements among human and non-human actors, infrastructures, technologies, and disciplinary assumptions. The emphasis is less on producing a single territorial proposal and more on unpacking cross-disciplinary tensions and identifying opportunities for bridging silos. Spatiality is conceptualized in "place-as-assemblage": dynamic alignments of buildings, people, signs, technologies, and institutional forces, as intervention within evolving socio-material configurations.

Taken together, these three workshops articulate a shared claim: that participatory design must be understood as situated spatial practice. They resist abstract notions of engagement detached from material contexts and instead foreground how territory, infrastructure, and place-based histories condition participation. Whether addressing mining conflicts, coastal regeneration, or interdisciplinary entanglements, they deploy spatial artifacts as epistemic and political devices. Mapping becomes a way of surfacing invisible infrastructures; charrettes create temporary publics that rehearse alternative spatial alignments; role-play destabilizes fixed stakeholder positions; and digital toolkits mediate scales of governance. Participation is thus rendered tangible, embodied, and negotiated through spatial media. This cluster shows that participation does not simply take place in space but is continuously produced through spatial and infrastructural arrangements that organise recognition, access, and legitimacy. Territories emerge here as contested configurations shaped by historical sedimentations, uneven distributions of power, and situated practices. Participatory design is implicated in these dynamics, as it contributes to reconfiguring the conditions through which participation becomes possible, visible, and actionable.

What is therefore at stake is the capacity to engage spatiality as a constitutive dimension of participation, where designing means intervening in the arrangements that enable or constrain collective action. At the same time, this cluster does not remain confined to geography or planning. It dialogues with broader concerns emerging across the positioning paper. The emphasis on conflict-sensitive planning aligns with peacebuilding and agonistic PD debates; the ecological framing of territory connects with regenerative and more-than-human design; the assemblage perspective bridges infrastructuring and pluriversal narratives. What distinguishes the Place, Spatiality, and Situated Participation cluster is its insistence that these themes are always grounded somewhere, materialized in specific territories, infrastructures, and spatial practices. In foregrounding place as constitutive, these workshops expand PD's repertoire for engaging complex socio-ecological transformations, reminding the field that democracy, coexistence, and regeneration are always spatially enacted and territorially contested.

3.3 Conflict, Dialogue, and Peacebuilding

This cluster, Conflict, Dialogue, and Peacebuilding, brings together workshops that approach conflict and peacebuilding as core PD concerns. Participation is framed as an ongoing process of engaging difference, negotiating power, and sustaining dialogue across organizational, communal, and place-based contexts. The selected workshops examine how peace is cultivated through everyday practices, material arrangements, and relational infrastructures rather than singular interventions. Across the cluster, participants work with artifact-based making, narrative and counter storying practices, role-play, and equity-centered frameworks to surface tensions, articulate competing perspectives, and prototype pathways toward more just forms of coexistence. Conflict appears as organizational misalignment, historical grievance, and structural inequality, addressed through design processes that hold plurality and enable collective sense-making over time. Design functions as a mediating practice that supports dialogue across scales, linking interpersonal encounters to institutional structures and broader societal dynamics. Together, these workshops position peacebuilding as participatory work grounded in situated action, relational accountability, and the continuous shaping of conditions for living together.

The workshop *Creative Dialogical Spaces for Agonism - Embodied Making and Material Dialogue in Contexts of Conflict and Transformation* by de Kreek et al. offers an example of participation as materialized dialogue under conditions of conflict. Situated in participatory design contexts where disagreement is frequently present, the workshop approaches dialogue as an embodied and material practice enacted through artefacts. Through a structured rotation across three stations (LEGO-based modelling of personal transitions, low-tech remix walls in post-conflict community settings, and commons-oriented mapping for shared governance) participants explore how artefacts mediate voice, power, and imagination across different scales and situations. The process foregrounds artefacts as active participants in dialogue, enabling indirect engagement with sensitive issues, surfacing disagreement, and carrying meanings across time. Participants respond not only to one another but also to artefacts left by previous groups, framing conflict as an ongoing, situated material conversation. Participation takes shape as a practice of sustaining agonistic spaces through making and material negotiation. By foregrounding embodied interaction and affective engagement with artefacts, the workshop also intersects with the cluster on narratives, emotions, and the politics of participation.

The workshop *From local action to global impact: companies as peace builders - Design tools to foster positive peace in organizations* by Lebano et al., offers an example of participation as organizational peacebuilding coming from a business context. Grounded in the concept of Positive Peace, the workshop situates companies as socio-political infrastructures whose everyday decisions

shape conditions of inclusion, cohesion, and conflict across scales. Participation unfolds within organizational life, from internal governance and workplace relations to supply chains and community engagement. Through co-design activities, role-play, and real-world scenario simulations, participants examine how business practices influence social resilience and collective well-being. The workshop emphasizes translating ethical commitments into concrete design tools, culminating in the co-creation of instruments that embed peace-oriented practices into organizational routines. For this reason, participation becomes a way of aligning internal structures with broader societal responsibilities. By extending participatory design into corporate and institutional settings, the workshop also connects with the cluster on place, spatiality, and situated participation, highlighting how organizational practices are embedded in wider socio-material contexts.

The workshop *Prototyping Place-based Pathways towards Peace: Cultivating Change through Counterstorying* by Lake and Marshall offers an example of participation as relational pathway-making. Situated in place-based PD practices, the workshop approaches peace as a plural and situated process shaped by local histories, power relations, and lived experience. Participation unfolds as a collective inquiry into how inequities, harm, and exclusion operate across social systems and how relational design practices can support more equitable conditions. Through methods such as counter-storytelling, intergroup dialogue, and equity-centered collective impact models, participants surface hidden histories and alternative narratives connected to place and peace. These narrative practices are combined with design activities that support the prototyping of context-specific strategies for systemic change, inviting participants to map cycles of harm alongside emerging cycles of care and justice. Participation takes shape as a practice of cultivating pathways toward peace grounded in difference, plurality, and equity. Through its emphasis on counter storying and collective sense-making, the workshop also intersects with the cluster on narratives, emotions, and the politics of participation.

Taken together, the workshops in this cluster argue that peacebuilding in participatory design cannot be understood as the technical management of disagreement nor as the achievement of consensus. It unsettles the persistent orientation of participatory design toward alignment and shared understanding. Participation is articulated here as an ongoing engagement with asymmetry, where conflict is not a problem to be resolved but a condition to be sustained. The question shifts from facilitating agreement to designing the conditions under which disagreement can persist without being neutralised or absorbed.

The workshops position peace as an ongoing design practice: the careful construction and maintenance of relational infrastructures capable of holding plurality, asymmetry, and historical tension without collapsing into antagonism. Thus, positioning PD as a practice fundamentally concerned with sustaining democratic life, where dialogue is a practice that must be actively designed, negotiated and renewed.

3.4 Narratives, emotions, and the politics of participation

Last cluster places storytelling, emotional engagement, and political awareness at the heart of PD. Narratives, emotions, and the politics of participation cluster purposefully diverge from viewing PD as a neutral, technical exercise, instead highlighting how narratives, affect, and power relations fundamentally shape the participatory process. By acknowledging that participation is influenced by the stories we construct, the emotions we encounter, and the underlying politics, this cluster challenges depoliticised and detached perspectives. It argues that documenting, reflecting on, and sharing experiences are inherently political acts, forming the core of PD practice.

All three workshops in this cluster share a central commitment as they recognise that participation cannot be separated from narrative and affective dimensions. Rather than treating emotions and values as peripheral, these proposals place them at the core of participatory processes. Each workshop contests the idea that PD is a purely objective or neutral activity, instead positioning it as a site where personal stories, feelings, and ethical considerations shape outcomes. By experimenting with alternative formats of documentation such as visual narratives, situated writing, and embodied reflection, the workshops collectively advance the notion that participation is a lived, relational practice. They challenge participants to reflect on the politics of representation, the role of emotions, and the ethical responsibilities in engaging with others. In doing so, they foster a more inclusive, caring, and politically conscious participatory design ethos.

The *Participatory Design Narratives: Embracing Emotions, Politics and Passions towards Dialogue and Coexistence* workshop by Del Gaudio et al. distinguishes itself by cultivating dialogue, care, and solidarity, especially in politically charged environments. It offers activities that help participants articulate their emotional experiences within PD contexts, breaking the silence around feelings that often go unacknowledged in research. By encouraging both expression and written reflection, the workshop positions emotions as sources of insight, critical to understanding the complexities of participation. The focus on caring and solidarity enables participants to navigate tensions, fostering a climate of mutual support and empathy. The workshop's unique contribution lies in its deliberate attention to how emotions interact with dialogue and narrative, reframing the role of affect as central to participatory practice.

Confessions of a Participatory Designer: Navigating Values Misalignment in Co-design Practice workshop proposed by Johnson and Hughes brings a candid, confessional format to the forefront, centering on values misalignment and the challenges practitioners face. By offering a safe space for honest discussion and practical advice, it allows participants to share their struggles and learn from experts. This workshop is unique in its explicit acknowledgement of the complexity and ambiguity inherent in participatory design. Rather than masking difficulties or pretending neutrality, it invites participants to confront the realities of misaligned values and conflicting priorities. The guidance provided helps practitioners develop clearer strategies for navigating these challenges, making the process more transparent and resilient. The confessional approach

legitimises vulnerability while also creating a shared repository of knowledge that can guide future practice.

The workshop *A Gendered Lens to Designing with Care to Recognise the 'Other'* by Gera and Navarrete Rigo, introduces a feminist perspective on care as a structuring principle of civic participation. Its uniqueness lies in positioning participation as both an ethical and affective *practic*e, shaped by collective reflection and relational accountability. Through group discussions, collaborative mapping, and shared synthesis, participants are encouraged to articulate culturally situated understandings of care and trace their interdependencies. The workshop foregrounds non-hierarchical relationships, social values, and collective agency, positioning personal experience as legitimate design knowledge. Participation unfolds through attentive listening, respect, and responsibility across individual, community, and global scales. By foregrounding care and lived experience, the workshop extends the logic of relational participation, connecting with broader themes such as multispecies coexistence and interdependence, as highlighted in other clusters.

The workshops open vital questions about the politics, the importance of affect, and the ethical responsibilities inherent in participatory design. Moving forward, there is a need to develop robust frameworks that integrate narrative and emotional dimensions more systematically into PD practice. This includes creating new methods for documenting and reflecting on participatory processes, methods that value lived experience, acknowledge power relations, and foster transparency. The workshops suggest that future efforts should focus on building inclusive participatory mechanisms that legitimise personal stories and emotional realities as sources of design knowledge. Additionally, there is scope for cross-pollination with other clusters, such as those emphasising more-than-human participation and care, to further enrich understandings of relational and interdependent coexistence.

Ultimately, the challenge is to move beyond theorising and to enact these principles in concrete, impactful ways. This requires ensuring forms of participation that are inclusive and caring, while also politically conscious and ethically grounded. By embracing narrative, affect, and politics as core components of PD, practitioners can foster more meaningful and transformative engagement, one that recognises the plurality of voices, experiences, and values shaping contemporary design realities.

4 Conclusion

The twelve workshops selected for PDC 2026 collectively reveal that participatory design practice is undergoing a significant evolution in line with what has been described as a fourth wave of PD [14]. Moving beyond participation as user involvement or stakeholder consultation, the workshops position participation as a political, relational, and infrastructural endeavor concerned with the conditions under which plural forms of coexistence might be sustained. In dialogue with the conference theme of *Peace, Dialogue, Coexistence*, these workshops offer a constellation of experimental practices that engage critically with contemporary challenges. The artefacts, protocols, and formats proposed carry political positions regarding what counts as knowledge, who can speak, and what futures are imaginable. Confession circles, pluriverse maps, and territory-personas, just to quote a few, operate as what might be described as *devices*, that more than capturing existing perspectives actively unlock availability for future research agendas exploring how workshops distribute agency, encode power relations and enable or foreclose several forms of coexistence.

The four clusters operate as an analytical synthesis of these orientations, making visible distinct yet interconnected trajectories within the field. Together, they point to an understanding of participatory design as situated within spatial, political, ecological, and affective conditions that actively configure participation. In this sense, the workshop track foregrounds a shift in participatory design from methods of inclusion toward practices that engage with the conditions through which participation becomes possible, legitimate, and sustainable. *Living Together Beyond the Human* expands the diversifying agenda of PD toward multispecies and ecological entanglements, questioning anthropocentric assumptions and exploring pluriverse dimensions of coexistence. *Place, Spatiality, and Situated Participation* foregrounds territory, infrastructure, and material context as constitutive of democratic engagement, positioning participation as spatially enacted and historically grounded. *Conflict, Dialogue, and Peacebuilding* frames peace as an ongoing, agonistic practice, designing for the productive negotiation of difference across organizational and community settings. *Narratives, Emotions, and the Politics of Participation* centers storytelling, affect, and care, emphasizing that participation is shaped by lived experience, ethical responsibility, and the politics of representation.

Together, these clusters create a workshop landscape that articulates participation as a relational, situated, and structurally embedded practice. As trajectories, these do not represent separation, but rather distinct concentrations of focus within the broader landscape. In this sense, the twelve workshops share common orientations in multiple ways. For instance, many employ artefact-based methods, such as mapping, speculative prototyping, charrettes, confession circles, and commons-based governance tools, as mediators of conflict and imagination. Another overlapping feature is the refusal to assume that participation is inherently harmonious. Many proposals explicitly foreground friction, values misalignment, and structural asymmetry as constitutive of democratic life. Rather than smoothing over disagreement in the name of consensus, many of these workshops are designed to hold tension productively.

Accordingly, several workshops within PDC 2026 acknowledge that living together may also entail sustaining the conditions under which disagreement remains generative rather than destructive. This calls for design capacities that warrant further investigation: how to hold conflict without resolving it prematurely; how to infrastructure dissent without producing paralysis; and how to create responsible spaces without reproducing extractive research relations.

To conclude, the workshop landscape at PDC 2026 can be understood as a site where the future methods, tools, and approaches of PD are actively negotiated. The workshop track represents an intense and concentrated arena for presenting, experiencing, discussing, reflecting upon, and co-developing workshop practices for further PD work, contributing to generating and transferring knowledge through making, testing participation, staging, and treating coexistence as practice.

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